

Pristiophorus japonicus

Japanese sawshark

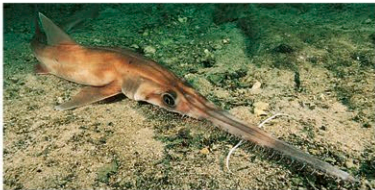


Length Up to 5 ft (1.5 m)
Weight Not recorded
Breeding Viviparous
Status Data deficient

Location W. North Pacific



The Japanese sawshark's body is flattened from top to bottom and has 2 dorsal fins. It has gills on the sides of its head, rather than underneath, as in rays. It has a pair of barbels on a saw-shaped snout, but it should not be confused with the superficially similar smalltooth sawfish (see p.485), which is a ray. Taste sensors on the barbels and snout are used to probe the seabed for small fishes or invertebrates. Its exceedingly sharp teeth are presumably used for destroying prey as well as for defence. Young Japanese sawsharks are born with large teeth, but these remain folded while the young are inside the mother to avoid injuring her.



Heterodontus portusjacksoni

Port Jackson shark



Length Up to 5½ ft (1.7 m)
Weight Not recorded
Breeding Oviparous
Status Least concern

Location Australia (including Tasmania), New Zealand



Like the horn shark (see below), this shark belongs to a family of 8 species that have bulky heads, powerful jaws, and crushing teeth. Its mouth points downward, enabling it to feed on starfish, sea urchins, and other seabed animals. The Port Jackson shark lives in inshore waters, and lays large, spiral-shaped egg cases.

HOME-LOVING

This shark maintains a home range and will return to the same area if displaced, though some migrate to Tasmania in summer.



Chiloscyllium plagiosum

Whitespotted bambooshark



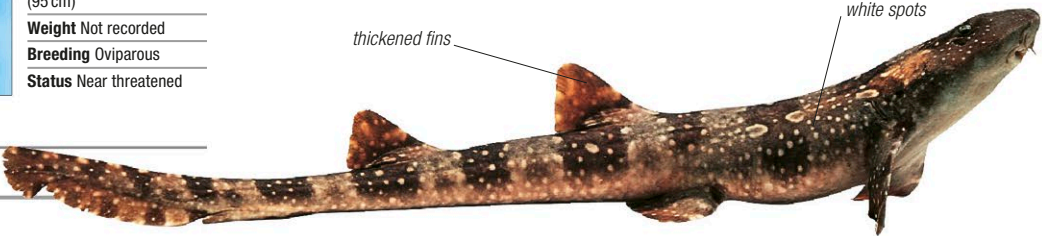
Length Up to 37 in (95 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Breeding Oviparous
Status Near threatened

Location Indo-Pacific, N. Australia



Its small size and attractive appearance have made this shark particularly popular with marine aquarists. It has a slender body, with white spots over a dark background and darker transverse bands. Short barbels on its mouth

help it to forage for food; the mouth is located well in front of the eyes. The whitespotted bambooshark uses its thickened pectoral and pelvic fins to clamber onto rocks.



Orectolobus maculatus

Spotted wobbegong



Length 6 ft (1.8 m), max 10 ft (3.2 m)
Weight Not recorded
Breeding Viviparous
Status Least concern

Location S. Australia



A large, slow-moving shark with a flattened body, the spotted wobbegong lives in shallow water close to the shore. Instead of actively hunting for food, it rests on the bottom, and ambushes animals that come within striking range. When the tide falls, it may haul itself from one rock pool to another, partly exposing itself to the air. Although generally unaggressive, spotted wobbegongs can inflict serious injuries if accidentally stepped on.

PERFECT DISGUISE



The spotted wobbegong's mottled coloring and flattened, textured body provide perfect camouflage on the seabed. Lured by the weedlike flaps of skin around its snout, lobsters, crabs, and octopus may swim right up to this shark's waiting mouth.

SPOTTED AND PATTERNED

The spotted wobbegong is elaborately patterned, with light, O-shaped spots and dark saddles on an olive background.



Hemiscyllium galei

Walking shark



Length 22 in (57 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Breeding Probably oviparous
Status Not evaluated

Location New Guinea



This spectacularly patterned shark belongs to a family of sluggish tropical inshore "bamboo sharks." It was recently discovered on shallow reefs of Geelvink Bay in Indonesian Papua and is marked

by dark "saddles" along its back that are dappled with white spots. There are also prominent dark spots running along each side of the body. Little is known about its habits, but it has been observed at night—at depths of 6½–13 ft (2–4 m)—"walking" along the reef bottom using its pectoral and pelvic fins. Like related species, it probably hunts for bottom-living fishes and invertebrates, and spends the day resting under rocks or corals.



Stegostoma fasciatum

Zebra shark



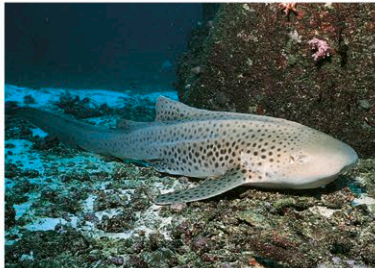
Length 9¼ ft (2.8 m), max 11 ft (3.5 m)
Weight Over 66 lb (30 kg)
Breeding Oviparous
Status Vulnerable

Location Indo-Pacific



Beige with brown spots, the zebra shark has an unusually flexible body that allows it to hunt out shrimps, crabs, and small bony fishes from tight crevices in the coral reefs where it lives. Its mouth,

located just behind the snout, points downward, enabling it to feed on mollusks that live on the seabed. During inactive periods, this shark rests on the seabed, propped up on its erect pectoral fins, facing the prevailing current. It is the only species in its family.



INSHORE MATING



During the breeding season, Port Jackson sharks come close inshore, where they mate and lay eggs. Females sometimes wedge the eggs in rocky crevices.